Tamam

By Betty Shamieh

My name is Tamam.
It means enough.

I was called that because my family wanted no more
daughters.
I am the last of seven sisters, good luck for the family.
After me, there were two brothers
and now there is only one.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

INTRODUCTION

Nelson Mandela once said "When a man is denied the right to live the life he believes in, he has no choice but to become an outlaw."

Everyone has heard of the Israel-Palestine conflict. Everyone knows it's bad, that it's been going on for a long time, and that there is a lot of hatred on both sides. We've heard of and live in fear of jihadists. We know the history of the persecution of Jewish people now living in Israel. We know the words "holocaust" and "the final solution." But we are removed . . . so removed from the daily conflict that it is almost impossible to understand how citizens of these countries, these two conflicting cultures, struggle to survive on a day to day basis.

In Tamam by Betty Shamieh, we hear firsthand from a young woman, the sister of a Palestinian suicide bomber, about her culture, her life, her fears and her family. Taman by Betty Shamieh.

Why do we rejoice when a boy is born?

Because we from Gaza understand the power of might.
The strong make the rules,
name the cities,
and decide who live in them,
or so they think.
We know what it means to be weak,
to cement a settlement of resentment,
brick by brick,

in our own ravaged hearts and shell-shocked minds,
with every corner
littered with bullets, tear gas canisters,
they say "Made in Pennsylvania" on them.

Times like these call for soldiers.
The ones we had have fallen.

A birth of a girl is different from a boy.
A girl is a gift that's too precious,
a reminder that soft things don't last long
in our world.
Parents here fool themselves,
thinking a boy child has at least almost
a fighting chance.

I want to talk about something smaller than me
that became bigger.

I want to talk about my brother.

Don't believe the stories you've heard.
I was far more religious than he.
I never had the heart to wake him to pray.
He was hoping to study medicine in Iraq
while building Israeli settlements in Gaza
so we could eat.
I let him sleep through the call.

He was caught with a rock in his hand
and a curse on his lips.
I went to the jail to visit my brother.
Most of my people looked at the Israeli guards,
with every ounce of hatred a human heart can hold,
their faces twisted not like they tasted something bitter,
like something bitter was forced down their throats.

I was smarter than that.

I knew I must navigate through the maze of might,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

and did my best to be kindly, polite.
Hoping perhaps that I would
remind them of a Rachel or Sarah or Ruth
that they knew or would have liked to know.
So when they beat my brother,
that thing that started out smaller than me and got bigger,
they would lighten their touch.

I am a pretty woman.
It's not a compliment, it's not a boast.
It's a fact.
Looks are a commodity, an asset, a possession I happen to possess.
It's why my grandmother said no,
when my sister's brother-in-law asked for my hand.
The family that was good enough
for my plain sister wasn't good enough for me.
I'm a pretty woman.
It's not a boast.
It's a fact.

And I smiled my best smile
when the soldiers opened the gate for me.
Weighed down with baskets of food,
I brought extra,
hoping to create the illusion
that that dirty jail was one place
where there was enough and extra for all
the guards to eat twice.
Otherwise, my brother would get none,
unless there was enough and extra.

They thanked me for the food and they raped me in front of him,
forcing my brother's eyes open so he had to watch.
They wanted to know something
that he preferred not to tell them.
They skewered the support for their argument into my flesh.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I'm told that their torture specialists who study the "Arab"
mind
realized rape would enrage our men.
Enraging a man is the first step on the stairway
that gets him to a place
where he becomes impotent,
helpless.

They not only refer to us as the cockroaches,
they examine us, experiment upon us,
as if we were that predictable, that much the same,
that easy to eradicate.
Their studies show the Arab men value the virtue of their
womenfolk,
Their studies show something within me was supposed to
be inviolate.

Say what you want about Arab men and women
and how we love one another,
There is one thing that's for certain.
There are real repercussions for hurting a woman in my
society.
There are repercussions.

When the first hand was laid upon me, we both screamed.
The evolutionary function of a scream is a cry for help,
they tied down the only one who could
so I silenced myself.
That was the only way to tell my brother
I didn't want him to tell.

I flinched when I had to,
but I kept my breathing regular.
My brother tried to look every other way,
but realized I needed him,
to look me in the eyes
and understand.

They thought making us face one another
in our misery would break us.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

But we were used to misery.
It's like anything else,
you can build up a tolerance for it.

Someone once told them what they wanted to know,
so they released my brother two weeks later.

That's when he built something
more intricate than the human heart,
hugged it to his chest,
and boarded a bus that was going nowhere and every-
where.
The day he did it, he told me over breakfast-

"Oppression is like a coin maker.
You put in human beings,
press the right buttons and
watch them
get squeezed, shrunk, flattened
till they take the slim shape of a two-faced coin.
One side is a martyr, the other a traitor.
All the possibilities of a life get reduced to those paltry
two.
The coin is tossed in the air
it spins once for circumstance,
twice for luck,
and a third time for predilection
before it lands flat.
The face that points down
towards hell
determines not only who you are,
but how you will become that way."

What he was really saying was good-bye.

Had I known, I would have said something more than
"It's interesting
you think oppression
makes us turn into a form of money, a currency.
How odd."

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Listen, I don't agree with killing innocent people
under any circumstances, ever.
The irony is
there were Palestinians who were Israeli citizens on that
bus too.
My brother wasn't counting on that.
No one was counting on that.

I want to feel sorrow when anyone is suffering,
No matter who they are or what their people have done to
mine,
no one's life should be snuffed out.
I am the kind of human being
who refuses to get high on the drug of hate.
In my opinion, that's the only kind of human being there is.

In other words, no one is going to reduce me to a coin.

There are absolutes,
it's wrong to kill, period.
And since the Israelis have killed five times the number of
my people,
as we have killed theirs,
I think they are five times as wrong.
It's hard to feel sad for them sometimes,
but I swear to you that I try my best.
But it's not easy.
They complain they can't go to a pizza parlor
while they bomb us in our homes.

I should have known what my brother was bound to do,
I could have stopped him.

I said every time he went out to face their guns with our
rocks.
"Don't go.
Let's achieve peace by peaceful means.
Let's use nonviolence.
Don't be a pawn.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

What kind of fool would face a gun with a rock?
Let others risk their lives.
They can never truly win.
They could kill every Palestinian and the wind will howl ~
our names and the rocks will"
rise up ,nd throw themselves,"

I'd always say, "Don't go."
But I didn't say,
"You are the most precious thing in the world to me.
The fact that you exist makes the earth spin on its axis,
it's rolling for joy because you are here.
The sun shows up to see you,
and the moon chases the sun off to be in your sky
and none of them love you like I do, brother.

Not even close.

There is no goal, no political means,
worth wrenching your life from mine.
If Palestine is Utopia, Palestine is already here.
Palestine is my brother being by my side
and screaming for joy when I have my firstborn
and living long and laughing loud with me
over hot tea and warm bread,
each morning,
which is all we can afford
but, if you are by my side, is more than enough.

If you think this is a gift for me,
the box will be empty, brother.
How can it not be?
Everything will be empty, if you're not here.

Don't hurt yourself and others in my name or for my sake.
I will not forgive you if you leave me.
I will not be comforted.
I will not be."

Instead I said, "don't go," and I didn't say it loud.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

They bulldozed our house
because you blew up that bus.
In all this, I didn't realize what true fear, true dread, was
till I watched our younger brother
watching them destroy our home,
witnessing each swoop and scoop,
with more anger in his eyes than I had ever seen in yours.

I was engaged to be married
to the love of my life and the richest man in Gaza.
My father went to his house
and told his father what had happened to me.
He didn't want scandal if we went ahead and married
and it was found I was not . . . . as I was before.
My love left me,
because of his father's insistence.
His mother, who never liked me anyway,
took him and married him to a girl from her town.
He moved to London with her
and I haven't seen him since.

I try to convince myself
that I wouldn't want to be married to a man
who could ever betray me.
I try to convince myself I'm better off without him.

Try is the operative word.
His cowardice was a violence
that hurts and haunts me more than what the guards did to
me.
Because I have no one to blame but my own people,
Which is as hard to do as blaming yourself.

I married my sister's brother-in-law,
who was made aware that I was not . . . as I was before.

My youngest brother went to Iraq
the week before my first child was born.
He went to study engineering.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I'm worried about him.
Our friends there say he disappears for months at a time.
He never tells me where he goes or when he'll return.

I'm worried about him.

My husband and I understand each other,
which is not exactly a good thing.
My husband never lets me live it down that my family
once rejected him,
He calls me a whore when he is angry
and stuck-up when he is not.

He get angry often,
Especially when I tell him he is worthless and not a man
when he can't find enough food.
It's the only way to make him steal it.
Like I said before, we understand one another.

I think of my first love who deserted me.
Every day, I visualize a new way I'd tell him
what a traitor he was to leave me,
in case I happen to ever see him again.
It makes me sad that,
though he wronged me in more ways than one,
He'll only have ears to listen to the first words I say.

You only get one chance to tell people they are wrong,
You get that chance because it takes people a minute or
two
to realize your'e telling them stuff they don't want to hear.
Then, they shut you out,
thought they might be still standing before you,
Smiling,
they make sure the door between the ear and the heart is
locked
And they forever take away your key.

Because they know if they keep listening,
they might not change,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

but it will be a little harder
to stay the same.

If I saw him today, I would tell him:
"You should have married me.
I was still a virgin, even after what the Israeli soldiers did to me.
I was still a virgin,
because I don't consider the men who raped me human and,
if you had any inkling of what a true man was
or how to be one,
neither would you."

My name is Tamam.
It means enough.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Betty Shamieh
Book: Talk to Me: Monologue Plays
ISBN: 978-1400076154
Publisher: Vintage
Date (Month/Year): Dec 2004

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY